

Jabberwocky

- *Lewis Carroll*



The Reverend Charles Lutwidge Dodgson, better known by the pen name Lewis Carroll, was an English author, mathematician, logician, Anglican clergyman and photographer.

His most famous writings are

Alice's Adventures in Wonderland and its sequel Through the Looking-Glass as well as the poems "The Hunting of the Snark" and "Jabberwocky", all considered to be within the genre of literary nonsense. Oxford scholar, Church of England Deacon, University Lecturer in Mathematics and Logic, academic author of learned theses, gifted pioneer of portrait photography, colourful writer of imaginative genius and yet a shy and pedantic man, Lewis Carroll stands pre-eminent in the pantheon of inventive literary geniuses.

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He also has works published under his real name.

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The Secret World of Lewis Carroll



Jabberwocky read by Benedict Cumberbatch



"Jabberwocky" is a nonsensical ballad written by the English poet Lewis Carroll in 1871. The poem appears in his novel, *Through the Looking Glass, and What Alice Found There*, the sequel to the famous *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*. In "Jabberwocky," Carroll uses nonsensical words throughout a typical ballad form to tell a tale of

good versus evil, which culminates in the killing of the fearsome Jabberwock. The poem is often praised not only for its creative language, but for its highly sonic and memorable nature, appealing just as much to our ears as it does to our imaginations.

Jabberwocky: Paraphrased.

It was around four o'clock in the afternoon, and the slimy toves bore holes in the side of the wet hill by spinning around. The borogoves were miserable, and the lost raths whistled and bellowed.

"Watch out for the Jabberwock, my son! Its jaws bite, and its claws could catch you! Watch out for the Jubjub bird, and avoid the fuming, furious Bandersnatch!"

Holding his vorpal sword, the son searched a long while for the fearsome beast. Then, he took a break next to a Tumtum tree and contemplated his situation.

While he was still thinking, the Jabberwock emerged from the dark woods with flaming eyes, making a bleating and warbling sound.

After a noisy clash, the son decapitated the Jabberwock with his sword. He hurried home triumphantly with the Jabberwock's head.

"And have you killed the Jabberwock? Give me a hug, my smiling son! What a fabulous and joyful day! Woo hoo! Hooray!" He chuckled and snorted in happiness.

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It was around four o'clock in the afternoon, and the slimy toves bore holes in the side of the wet hill by spinning around. The borogoves were miserable, and the lost raths whistled and bellowed.

Themes:

GOOD V/S EVIL

Amidst the whimsical language of "Jabberwocky" lies a seemingly simple tale of good versus evil: a son embarks on a quest to kill a fearsome beast, the Jabberwock, before returning victorious to his father. Yet while upon first glance the poem suggests the inevitable triumph of good over evil, the repetition of the final stanza implies this might not be the case. On the contrary, this repetition suggests that the hero's victory has had little impact on the rest of this world. If that's true, then perhaps the poem argues that the fight against evil is never complete, because danger is always lurking.

The hero's father warns him early on to "beware" three mysterious beasts: the "Jabberwock," the "Jubjub bird," and the "Bandersnatch." The repetition of "beware" in lines 5 and 7 invites anticipation of these strange threats and signals that they are worth fearing despite their silly names. On a sonic level, the short, hard consonant sounds in words like "claws," "catch," "shun," and "snatch" (in Bandersnatch) are rough and unpleasant to the ear, perhaps not unlike the things they describe. Yet even after reading the poem's accompanying text, *Through the Looking-Glass*, and *What Alice Found There*, readers don't have a clear idea of what these beasts look like, nor why the hero is instructed to "beware" them. Their dangerous potential is uncertain, and this makes them all the more frightening. In this sense, Carroll is connecting evil to a fear of the unknown—which is perhaps harder to defeat than a physical monster.

Carroll does later offer a bit more clarity as to what the hero is up against. Just before the loud and hostile Jabberwock emerges from the woods, the hero rests contemplatively by a tree. In line 14, the

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Jabberwock interrupts the hero's peace with "eyes aflame" and "bubbling" sounds. These contrasting images, one peaceful and the other violent, help to separate good from evil on a visual level. On an auditory level, readers can contrast the Jabberwock's sounds with the father's jolly "Callooh! Callay!" (which are joyous—even humorous—rather than menacing).

Yet, despite Carroll describing the Jabberwock as having "eyes," "jaws," "claws," and a "head," readers still don't actually know what it looks like. Instead, Carroll relies only on these simple bodily fragments to present his monster, leaving readers with the task of filling in the gaps. The fact that the Jabberwock remains visually mysterious allows readers' imaginations to run wild, perhaps coming up with something far more terrifying than anything Carroll could ever specifically describe. Once again, the threat or anticipation of an unknown evil is perhaps the most frightening thing about it.

Finally, the fact that the poem begins and ends with the same stanza may be a visual suggestion that the hero has returned home after defeating the enemy and that all is well. Yet, even if we take the time to

decipher the words in this stanza (with the help of Through the Looking Glass), it's still an unsettling and even foreboding finale. In it, slimy, badger-like creatures called "toves" bore holes in the side of a hill while borogoves and raths (other strange Carrollian creatures) make bellowing sounds. We can only guess as to the significance of this scene, and its presence instills a sense of mystery, or of lying-in wait, from the poem's onset. If the poem began in mystery, why might the repeated stanza at the end not cause the same effect?

Thus, while this specific quest may be resolved with the Jabberwock's death, we are left to wonder if another threat, perhaps the "frumious Bandersnatch," could be waiting. Even at the point of conflict resolution, we are left uncertain about the presence of evil. Is the story really over? Or is there something else we should "beware?"

NONSENSE AND STORYTELLING

In "Jabberwocky," Carroll combines a familiar form and narrative with very unfamiliar language. Most

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of his invented words have meanings, as readers can learn from *Through the Looking-Glass*, and *What Alice Found There*, but their initial effect within the poem is one of confusion and nonsense. In most cases, readers can't fully make sense of a poem if they do not know all the words. But by organizing his language in the form of a ballad as well as by framing his tale as a traditional heroic quest, Carroll suggests that it's very possible to imbue nonsensical language with meaning simply through context. Nonsensical language can also make familiar stories seem humorously strange and allows Carroll to gently poke fun at (or, more generously, breathe life into) clichéd adventure stories: so familiar are these tales that they make sense even with made-up words slotted into them like a Mad Lib.

The rhyme scheme and meter of the poem resemble those of a ballad, which is a verse form that tells a story using four-line stanzas (a.k.a. quatrains). With this organization, Carroll's words invite readers' curiosity: there's something reassuring about a poem that rhymes along a specific meter even if the words of the poem itself are nonsensical, for they at least make

sense on a basic auditory level. In other words, the poem sounds like a certain kind of story. This form allows words like "toves," "wabe," "borogoves," and "outgrabe" to resonate with whimsy. If they didn't rhyme or obey a specific structure, readers would likely be less tolerant of their oddity. Instead, it's easy enough to imagine the gist of the scene despite about half of the words not being actual words.

The poem's questing narrative is also common enough for readers to recognize it beneath all the nonsense. We know that a hero sets out to kill a monster (the Jabberwock), even if we don't fully understand the monster's identity or the general setting. The heroic quest is a tried-and-true plot, which allows readers to fill in what they don't understand with their imaginations.

For example, in the fifth stanza, the hero's "vorpal" blade goes "snicker-snack," after which the Jabberwock dies and the hero goes "galumphing back." We know that these words describe a fight scene between the hero and the Jabberwock even without knowing the words "vorpal," "snicker-snack," or "galumphing." We can

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Materials compiled by Mr Sangeeth SG, Assistant Professor, Jain (Deemed-to-be-University)

make educated guesses about their meanings because of the common narrative of heroes battling monsters. They also sound similar to those meanings (e.g. "galumphing" sounds like "galloping" and "triumphant" at the same time, suggesting the hero's happy, quick return).

The namesake of the poem, the Jabberwock, is perhaps the most striking blend of nonsense and familiarity. Although it has "eyes aflame" and makes a "bubbling" noise, its image is undefined. For all we know, it might have wings, horns, or an otherwise odd arrangement of body parts. Yet neither its strange name nor its lack of a full description deter readers from understanding that it is a beast worth fearing. Monsters are historically menacing because they are often not fully described (e.g., a mysterious monster hiding under the bed). In this sense, the Jabberwocky's lack of description actually is familiar because it could look like anything.

In this way, Carroll relies on our imaginations (and our familiarity with monsters) to render an image

of the Jabberwock. No two readers' conceptions of the Jabberwock will likely be the same, but that is part of the magic of Carroll's trust in his readers' ability to weave meaning from nonsense.

Suggested Nonsensical Poems 🎬

Hey Diddle Diddle - Anonymous

The Great Panjandrum Himself – Samuel Foote

The Walrus and the Carpenter – Lewis Carroll

The Owl and the Pussy Cat – Edward Lear

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The Sandbox (One-Act-Play)

- *Edward Albee*



Edward Franklin Albee III was an American playwright known for works including *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*, *The Zoo Story*, *The Sandbox* and *The American Dream*. His works are considered well-crafted and often unsympathetic

examinations of the modern condition. His early works reflected a mastery and Americanization of the Theatre of the Absurd that found its peak in works by European playwrights such as Jean Genet, Samuel Beckett, and Eugène Ionesco. Younger American playwrights, such as Pulitzer Prize-winner Paula Vogel, credit Albee's daring mix of theatricalism and biting dialogue with helping to reinvent the post-war American theatre in the early 1960's. Albee's dedication to continuing to evolve his voice — as evidenced in later productions such as *The Goat* or *Who is Sylvia* (2000) — also routinely marks him as distinct from other American playwrights of his era.

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Albee himself described his work as "an examination of the American Scene, an attack on the substitution of artificial for real values in our society, a condemnation of complacency, cruelty, and emasculation and vacuity, a stand against the fiction that everything in this slipping land of ours is peachy-keen."

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Edward Albee Interview



An Amateur Production of the Sandbox



Edward Albee wrote *The Sandbox* on commission from the Festival of Two Worlds at the Spoleto Festival in Italy in 1959. Its first production took place in New York the following year. *The Sandbox* is linked to a longer play by Albee titled *The American Dream*, a play he had written earlier in his career. For *The Sandbox*, he plucked characters from his full-length work and created a 14-minute absurd meditation on death and grief.

The Sandbox is dedicated to Albee's grandmother on his mother's side, an influential figure in his life, and follows an abstracted depiction of the death of "Grandma," an older woman who, in her dotage, is cared for by "Mommy" and "Daddy." The "sandbox" of the title is a small playing area situated upstage, where a

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muscular young man does calisthenics. While he does not speak much in the play, we learn by the end that he is both a young aspiring actor in Southern California, and the "Angel of Death."

Self-referential components associated with postmodernism are used throughout the play, with actors inserting commentary on the events taking place and speaking directly to the audience and alluding to the theatricality of the space itself. The characters are aware that they are not in a realistic space, but instead inside a highly abstracted stage space, and allude to this knowledge throughout. The result is a kind of psychoanalytic dreamscape, one in which characters are defined and signified by their familial relationships or by their relationship to the stage. A musician accompanies the proceedings and Grandma makes a curiously affectionate connection with the Young Man, as he gently and indirectly ushers her towards death.

In spite of its distinctly absurdist nature, *The Sandbox* is considered one of Edward Albee's most autobiographical works. The playwright himself continued to insist it was his finest play even after

Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf? became one of the defining stage dramas of the 1960s.

Summary:

The play opens with a Young Man doing calisthenics behind a sandbox at the brightest time of day. Mommy and Daddy enter; Daddy says he's cold, and Mommy says it's warm as toast. They are looking for a place to put Grandma. Mommy asks Daddy his opinion, but he doesn't have much of an opinion. A Musician comes onstage and Mommy cues him to begin playing. The pair bring out Grandma, who looks afraid, and place her in the sandbox. After Mommy and Daddy take their seats at the front of the stage, Grandma throws sand at Mommy with a plastic shovel that is in the sandbox.

Grandma addresses the audience, explaining that she is 86 and was married at 17, to a farmer. Her husband died when she was 30 and she was left to bring up Mommy all by herself. Grandma asks the Musician to stop playing, and then notices the Young Man and asks

him his name. He doesn't know, as he is an actor and the movie studios haven't given him one yet. Grandma then tells the audience that Mommy married Daddy, a very rich man, and they brought her from the farm to live in their home in the city. They made space for her under the stove and gave her an army blanket, and her own dish.

The Musician begins to play again as the lights dim and it becomes night. Mommy and Daddy recognize that it is night and know that death is coming for Grandma when they hear an offstage rumble. Grandma tells them to be quiet as it hasn't happened yet. Grandma then dies and the lights return to brightest day. Mommy and Daddy put away their mourning and exit.

Grandma attempts to move but cannot. The Young Man comes over to her and tries to silence her. She continues to speak and he tells her that he has a line to say. She lets him say that he is the Angel of Death, and he kisses her on the forehead. She tells him that the

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way he said it was very nice, that he has a certain quality. The Young Man is appreciative. The Musician plays.

Characters:

GRANDMA

The 86-year-old protagonist of the play and the mother of Mommy. Grandma is simultaneously shrewd and childlike, often to the chagrin of her daughter. She represents a rural ideal and raised her daughter on a farm before Mommy moved her to the city. She is alternately sarcastic and warm, and has a special confidence with the audience.

MOMMY

Grandma's 55-year-old daughter, a domineering and outspoken person. Mommy has very little respect for those around her, including her own mother, and often tends towards cruelty. She operates under the delusion that she has cared well for her mother and affects sadness at the prospect of her death, but quickly moves on.

DADDY

The 60-year-old wealthy husband of Mommy. Daddy is extremely passive and does whatever Mommy asks of him, having very few opinions of his own.

THE YOUNG MAN

A handsome stranger whom the family sees performing calisthenics near the sandbox. It is revealed that he is in fact the Angel of Death, come to take Grandma away. As Grandma discovers, he is an actor from Southern California, who dreams of being in the movies. While he is very attractive, he is not all that bright or skilled as an actor.

THE MUSICIAN

An unnamed character who doesn't speak. The Musician accompanies the family to the beach, playing music when asked, although it is not specified what kind.

Themes:

DEATH

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Death is the central theme of the play as the play itself is a theatricalization of Grandma's death. While the events onstage do not reflect traditional images or markers of death, certain elements, such as the Musician, and the fact that the Young Man is presented as the "Angel of Death," suggest that we are watching a version of Grandma's funeral. We never see Grandma actually die, but various stage antics, such as her piling sand on herself, and her not being able to move, represent her passage from life to death.

BAD MARRIAGE

Daddy is described by Albee as a small man, grey and thin. During the play Mommy asks his opinion of things, but he never has a strong one, opting to do whatever Mommy wants to do. Mommy and Daddy bicker and rarely see eye-to-eye, but they uphold the image of their marriage for the sake of appearances.

INDIGNITY

Grandma explains how she married a farmer at 17 and he died when she was 30. Mommy is their child, who Grandma raised alone. When Mommy married

Daddy, she came into a lot of money and took Grandma off her farm to live in their townhouse in the city. As Grandma describes it, however, they put her under the stove, giving her only an army blanket and a dish. Albee shows that Grandma is a woman who has been through a great deal of hardship, yet is only given the bare essentials and no respect. We see this clearly as well from the fact that Mommy and Daddy bring Grandma to the beach to die, a place she does not care to be. Even the way they carry her out by her armpits and plop her in a sandbox to wait for her to die represents their lack of respect for her.

Play it Out! 🎭

Riders to the Sea - John Millington Synge

The Lesson - Eugene Ionesco

Defeat - John Galsworthy

The Bald Soprano - Eugene Ionesco

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